



Medicine and Pregnancy: An Overview

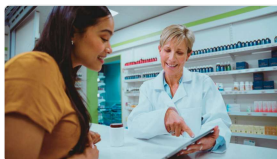
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For Everyone

KEY POINTS

- Medicine use in pregnancy is common.
- If you're pregnant or thinking of getting pregnant, talk to your healthcare providers before starting or stopping any medicines.



Background

Almost all pregnant women face decisions about taking medicines during pregnancy. Many need to take medicines during pregnancy to treat health conditions. In some cases, avoiding or stopping a medicine during pregnancy may be more harmful than taking it.

And yet, certain medicines during pregnancy can increase the risk for health problems, such as some birth defects, prematurity, or pregnancy loss.

What the data shows

Medicine use during pregnancy is common. About 9 in 10 women report taking some type of medicine during pregnancy. About 7 in 10 report taking at least one prescription medicine. From 1997–2018, use of at least one prescription medication in the first trimester increased 35%. [\[1\]](#) [\[2\]](#)

Safety information is lacking. Fewer than 10% of medicines approved since 1980 have enough information to determine their safety during pregnancy. This is because pregnant women are often not included in studies that determine the safety of new medicines. [\[3\]](#)

As a result, women and healthcare professionals have limited information to make informed treatment decisions during pregnancy.

Common questions

Is it safe for me to take medicines before I get pregnant?

Many women need to take medicine to stay healthy before and during pregnancy. If you're planning to become pregnant, you should discuss your current medicines with your healthcare provider. Creating a treatment plan for your health condition before pregnancy can help keep you and your baby healthy.

Should I take acetaminophen during pregnancy?

Some studies of acetaminophen during pregnancy have shown an association with neurological conditions such as autism and ADHD, particularly when taken chronically throughout pregnancy. Although a direct causal relationship between acetaminophen and autism or ADHD has not been established, pregnant women should consider avoiding acetaminophen use during pregnancy as a precaution. [Although high fevers have been shown to be associated with birth defects](#), [low grade fevers](#) generally do not require any medication. If a pregnant woman is ever in doubt about fevers, she should consult with a physician about treatment options.

I took a medicine before I knew I was pregnant. What do I do?

If you're concerned about medicines you took before you knew you were pregnant, talk with your healthcare provider about your concerns. Some medicines can be harmful when taken during pregnancy, but others are unlikely to cause harm. If you're concerned and cannot reach your doctor, contact an expert for free at [MotherToBaby](#).

Should I trust online information about medicine safety in pregnancy?

Use caution when consulting online sources about medicine safety in pregnancy. Instead, use the information you find to start a conversation with a healthcare professional. Many websites post lists of medicines that are "safe" to take during pregnancy. However, for many medicines listed, there is not enough scientific evidence of their safety during pregnancy.

Can I take medicine once I'm no longer pregnant? Can I take medicines if I'm breastfeeding?

Although many medications do pass into breast milk, most have little or no effect on milk supply or on infant well-being. For more detailed information, [LactRx](#) is an online database that provides information about managing your health conditions while breastfeeding.

What's being done

CDC and partners study medicine use in pregnancy to understand how specific medicines might affect pregnancy. Results of these studies provide better information on the safety and risks of using specific medicines before, during, and after pregnancy.

This information can help you weigh the risks and benefits of medicines. It can also help you and your healthcare provider make decisions about treatment options.

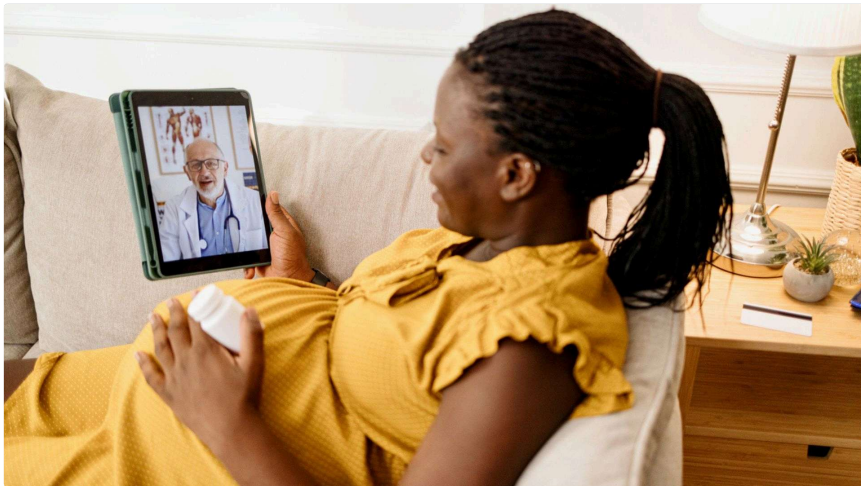
KEEP READING

[Research on Medicines and Pregnancy](#)

What you can do

Talk to your healthcare providers before starting or stopping any medicines. Be sure to discuss the following with your healthcare providers:

- All medicines you take, including prescriptions, over-the-counter medicines, herbal and dietary supplements, and vitamins
- Best ways to keep any health conditions you have under control
- Your personal goals and preferences for the health of you and your baby



Talk to your healthcare provider about any medicines you take.

Resources

[Food and Drug Administration](#) (FDA)'s website contains information about taking medicines during pregnancy. FDA also maintains an alphabetical index of [safety information for specific drugs](#).

[MotherToBaby](#) provides information and [fact sheets](#), in English and Spanish. These materials describe the risks and safety of taking specific medicines during pregnancy and breastfeeding. You can contact MotherToBaby, whose experts can answer questions in English or Spanish, by phone, chat, or email. This service is free and confidential.

- Call 1-866-626-6847
- Chat live or send an email [MotherToBaby](#)

The US HHS's Office of Women's Health provides free, reliable health information for women everywhere. The site contains a database of resources on many topic areas, such as [pregnancy and medicine](#).

[LactRx](#) is a database that contains information about specific medicines and ways they might affect breastfeeding mothers and their babies. This resource also describes potential alternatives to consider, if needed.

SOURCES

CONTENT SOURCE:
[National Center on Birth Defects and Developmental Disabilities](#)

REFERENCES

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2. Werler MM, Kerr SM, Ailes EC, Reefhuis J, Gilboa SM, Browne ML, Kelley KE, Hernandez-Diaz S, Smith-Webb RS, Garcia MH, Mitchell AA and The National Birth Defects Prevention Study and Birth Defects Study To Evaluate Pregnancy exposureS. Patterns of Prescription Medication Use during the First Trimester of Pregnancy in the United States, 1997–2018. *Clin Pharmacol Ther.* 2023. <https://doi.org/10.1002/cpt.2981>
3. Adam MP, Polifka JE, Friedman JM. Evolving knowledge of the teratogenicity of medications in human pregnancy. *Am J Med Genet Part C.* 2011;157:175-82.